

The First Few Minutes: When a Student Loses It

For the adult in the room right after a blow-up. Your response, the room, and the referral.

CLASSROOM MANAGEMENT

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

If anyone could get hurt, get another adult.

Restraint and seclusion are not de-escalation tools. Imminent danger only, trained staff only. [NASP 2021]

YOUR RESPONSE COMES FIRST

- **Lower your voice. Slow your movements.**

Keep instructions few and clear. State plainly what behaviour you expect right now. [NCTSN, Psychological First Aid for Schools]

SAY

I need you to stop that. We will sort the rest out after.

- **Hold the boundary without piling on.**

Set a firm limit on the behaviour. Decide any consequence after things are calm, logically rather than punitively. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.5]

- **Give one safe choice.**

Loss of control is often part of what the student is reacting to. One real, small choice beats a string of instructions. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.5]

SAY

You can sit here, or stand by the door. Your choice.

DO NOT ASSUME YOU KNOW THE REASON

- **Blowing up at correction can be a trauma reaction, not defiance.**

That does not remove the boundary above. It should stop you deciding you know the cause before anyone trained has looked. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.4]

AFTER THE MOMENT, NOT DURING IT

- **Support, then refer.**

Offer support yourself if you can, or refer the student to your counsellor or school mental health professional. [NCTSN PFA, Core Action 3]

SAY

I want to talk about this later, just us. Not now.

- **Give it a time and a place.**

Set aside an actual time to talk about what happened, rather than processing it in front of the class. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.5]

WHEN TO ESCALATE

- **Severe, or happening repeatedly? Refer it.**

You do not need to be certain what is behind it first. Let a school mental health professional make that call. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.6]

- **Suspect abuse? Follow your district reporting procedure.**

Separately, and without waiting on anything above. Your district policy governs the procedure. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.4]

What is deliberately not here

Breathing exercises, calming scripts, or any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.

Sources: NCTSN Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators pp.4-6; NCTSN Psychological First Aid for Schools, Core Action 3; NASP 2021 on restraint and seclusion.